

The Gravy Train

Buchanan's wanting to play more foreign players on the field brings out a sharp divide between the Indians and the imports

One explanation offered for John Buchanan's lack of success with the Kolkata Knight Riders came from a senior Australian cricketer on the team he coached to two World Cup wins and overwhelming dominance from 1999 to 2007. The player who must remain unnamed said Buchanan's skill as a coach was very specific: he could make a well-trained, elite team raise its game but could not work with disparate players of different skill levels.

The IPL has strengthened that argument about Buchanan. The coach himself has blamed some of his team's struggles on the squad's inability to field more overseas players. IPL teams can buy up to 10 foreign players but can only field four in a game. Buchanan said, "It is a question that we have posed to the IPL a number of times, about the involvement of more (foreign) players on the field." Buchanan has had bowlers like \$600,000-man Mashrafe Mortaza, Ajantha Mendis and Charl Langeveldt on the bench because of the four-player cap and said, "At the moment we have adopted a batting strategy, so that's where our international effort is." Glenn McGrath too has had to sit out of the Delhi Daredevils XI as the less-heralded Dirk Nannes has shone. When Daredevils coach Greg Shipperd came out in support of Buchanan, he was told off by his management for commenting on policy matters rather than cricket.

The push for more foreign players is a prickly subject and has previously come from teams like the Royal Challengers and Kings XI Punjab. With big-ticket overseas players, they wanted the cap on foreign players per team to be raised from four to five. The subject came up during the February auction in Goa and the request was turned down. IPL Commissioner Lalit Modi says the issue is "dead and buried" and that there would be no rethink on the cap.

Indians increasingly believe that the IPL has become a gravy train, particularly for foreign support staff who bring in friends in superfluous roles or get contracts for players from their home states. "The BCCI will never agree to raise the cap—they have state associations to answer to," said an official. The arc lights of the IPL may have distracted some imports from more mundane tasks at hand. One whisper from the Bangalore camp suggested that Challengers captain Kevin Pietersen actually did not know some of the Indians on his team-sheet.

KKR'S MULTINATIONAL MIX IN A RARE MOMENT OF CELEBRATION



thinking about the simple things. We're not doing the simple things well." Days of fielding practice in India and South Africa ended with no clarity about who would man specialist positions. Players dropped after one match were told that 'rotation' was in order so that everyone needed to be in 'match-mode' in time for the semis. But Morne van Wyk, one of the two South African signings, was not played until the slide began. The other, Charl Langeveldt, a South African T20 stalwart, didn't get a game in home conditions until it was too late. There was a dug-out flare-up between a former India cricketer and a coach, after he was 'substituted', football-style, following a misfield.

But the consequences are coming, complete with a James Earl Jones voiceover. Shah Rukh has held 3 a.m. teleconferences with his management, trying to make sense of the apocalypse. Buchanan came close to losing his job after the sixth defeat but held on to it only because no one wanted to look like Vijay Mallya having a mid-life, mid-season fit.

It is unlikely Buchanan & Co will be back next year. The team management is also looking to hire the kind of Indian cricketing intermediary that exists in one or the other form on most teams to bridge the gap between Indian and overseas personnel.

Then there is the small matter of 'Kolkata', the word, which has gone missing from the team jersey. The grapevine says Shah Rukh is fed up of dealing with Kolkata's obdurate cricket administration and wants the team to move to another city, a charge denied by the KKR management. The holding company, they say, is Knight Riders Sports Private Limited and the team will always be the Kolkata Knight Riders. The logo minus the 'Kolkata' was merely a design alternative.

In turn, Kolkata seems to have distanced itself too after cult hero Ganguly was unseated and sidelined. Once hot sellers, KKR merchandise has just stopped moving. The team that everyone once wanted a piece of, might just have lost more than its fans. It may already have lost its hold on home. ■